

The Washington Post

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Democracy Dies in Darkness

WEDNESDAY, APRIL 23, 2025 • \$4

Sweeping shake-up planned at State Dept.

Rubio's proposal would cut some programs but has no immediate layoffs

BY ADAM TAYLOR,
JOHN HUDSON,
DAN DIAMOND
AND HANNAH NATANSON

Secretary of State Marco Rubio on Tuesday unveiled a plan to significantly reorganize the State Department, saying the redesign would reverse “decades of bloat and bureaucracy” and seek to eradicate what he suggested was an ingrained “radical political ideology.”

The proposed shake-up of the United States’ primary foreign policy institution coincides with the Trump administration’s efforts to reorient the country on the world stage to align with the president’s “America First” agenda while cutting costs and downsizing staff across the federal government.

The effort targets some human rights programs and others focused on war crimes and democracy, according to internal documents shared with The Washington Post. As part of the plan, senior officials would submit to department leadership a path to reduce U.S.-based staff by 15 percent, according to the documents, potentially affecting hundreds of jobs, though there would be no immediate layoffs.

SEE REORGANIZATION ON A7

EPA tumult: Over 450 justice and DEI staffers receive notices. **A3**

Minimal support for millionaire tax hikes

Handful of Trump allies backing concept see it as a way to recoup revenue

BY JEFF STEIN

President Donald Trump’s inner circle is weighing whether the White House should back raising taxes on Americans earning more than \$1 million per year as part of the GOP’s 2025 tax legislation, according to two administration officials and three other people briefed on the matter.

While the prospect of a tax hike has gotten a largely chilly reception among Republicans on Capitol Hill, Vice President JD Vance and budget director Russell Vought have expressed openness to the idea in internal administration deliberations and are viewed as supportive, said the people, who spoke on the condition of anonymity to describe private talks. Stephen K. Bannon, who served as the president’s chief strategist during his first term, has been publicly urging Trump to endorse the plan in part as a way to defang Democratic attacks on the GOP as the party of the rich.

The concept, however, faces strenuous opposition, including from longtime allies of the president. Outside Trump advisers Newt Gingrich, Steve Moore and Larry Kudlow have come out

SEE TAX ON A4

High court considers parents’ rights in education



JOHN MCDONNELL/FOR THE WASHINGTON POST

A member of the Rainbow Defense Coalition blows bubbles at a rally Tuesday outside the Supreme Court in support of LGBTQ-themed books in Montgomery County schools. The justices seemed open to arguments that requiring children to participate in talks on gender and sexuality conflicts with parents’ religious rights. **Story, A3**

U.S. proposal would recognize Crimea as Russian

BY SIOBHÁN O’GRADY,
JOHN HUDSON
AND STEVE HENDRIX

KYIV — Ukrainian and European officials meeting in London on Wednesday will be faced with a fast-moving U.S. proposal to recognize Russia’s illegal annexation of Crimea and freeze the war’s front lines as part of a peace agreement, according to several people familiar with internal delibera-

Stance comes ahead of talks in London with Ukraine, European allies

tions.

Ukraine’s allies are hoping to win security guarantees and reconstruction programs for the embattled country in exchange

for any such territorial concessions.

The U.S. proposals, presented to Ukraine in Paris last week, include having Washington formally recognize annexed Crimea as Russian territory and eventually lifting sanctions against Russia under a future accord, according to three people familiar with the matter. In exchange, Moscow would end hostilities in Ukraine at a time when Russia’s military

enjoys battlefield momentum and sizable advantages in troop strength and weaponry.

Ukrainian President Volodymyr Zelensky told reporters Tuesday that Ukraine would not recognize Crimea as Russian, noting that it would violate the country’s constitution to do so. Discussing

SEE UKRAINE ON A10

Weaponry: Ukraine, fearing U.S. aid cuts, boosts artillery production. **A8**



MAANSI SRIVASTAVA/FOR THE WASHINGTON POST

Jennifer Vasquez Sura, wife of Kilmar Abrego García, at a rally this month in Greenbelt, Maryland.

‘I just want my husband back’

Wife and family of wrongly deported man are swept up in a political frenzy

BY MARÍA LUISA PAÚL

The wife of Kilmar Abrego García, the Maryland man mistakenly deported to a notorious prison in El Salvador by the Trump administration, has been moved to a safe house by supporters after U.S. officials posted a court document on social media that included the family’s address.

Jennifer Vasquez Sura said in an interview with The Washington Post that she began fearing for her safety and that of their three children — two of whom are autistic — after verbal attacks on her husband by President Donald Trump himself, as well as taunts on social media by administration officials and Salvadoran President Nayib Bukele.

The couple’s home was usually filled by the sounds of a burgeoning family, including pans clattering while her husband cooked, the three kids tumbling through the day, the TV humming in the background. Now, she is on her own

SEE ABREGO GARCÍA ON A6

Diplomatic talks: U.S. discussed case with El Salvador, filing says. **B1**

Kennedy plans to phase out synthetic food dyes

Crackdown on color additives has been a focus of his agenda

BY RACHEL ROUBEIN

Robert F. Kennedy Jr.’s health department announced plans to phase out petroleum-based synthetic dyes from the nation’s food supply in a bid to ramp up pressure on an industry he has often derided.

The Department of Health and Human Services said it aims to work with the industry to eliminate six synthetic dyes — such as red dye No. 40 and yellow dye No. 5 — from the food supply by the end of 2026.

“One by one we’re going to get rid of every ingredient and additive in food that we can legally address,” Kennedy said.

Kennedy, the nation’s top health official, made the announcement Tuesday afternoon, along with Marty Makary, the newly confirmed head of the Food and Drug Administration. The move comes as Kennedy has claimed that food makers have been allowed to “mass poison” American children. He has frequently blasted controversial food dyes that can be found in snacks, cereals, drinks and candy, and he has made cracking down on color additives a top

target of his “Make America Healthy Again” initiative to root out chronic disease and childhood illness.

When asked whether there was a formal agreement with the food companies on the phaseout, Kennedy said, “We don’t have an agreement; we have an understanding.”

The goal, Makary said, is for food companies to eliminate the dyes from products voluntarily. He said manufacturers “want to do it,” rather than contend with a patchwork of state laws.

“Let’s start in a friendly way and see if we can do this without any statutory or regulatory changes, but we are exploring every tool in the toolbox to make sure this gets done very quickly,” Makary said.

It was not immediately clear whether all food companies would adhere to the ask. The dairy industry said it would voluntarily work to remove such dyes, while the color additive industry stood by the safety of the dyes.

“Consumer Brands has long asked HHS and FDA to reestablish themselves as the country’s leading regulatory authority and we appreciate that the administration has reasserted their leadership in response to the myriad of state activity in the food regulation space,” Melissa Hockstad, the chief executive of Consumer Brands Association, a

SEE FOOD DYES ON A4

IN THE NEWS

Survivor’s story A woman trapped in the 1995 Oklahoma City bombing reinvented her life entirely, saying she’s “living on borrowed time” and wants to make the most of it. **A5**

Book removals After titles were stripped from Naval Academy shelves, a group seeks to make them as accessible as possible. **B1**

THE NATION Prosecutors resigned, claiming they were told to admit “wrongdoing” in Eric Adams’s case. **A2**
The Education Department will soon resume garnishing wages for student loan debt. **A4**

THE WORLD Catholicism continued to lose ground in Latin America under the first pope from the region. **A11**
Gunmen killed or wounded a large number of tourists in Indian-administered Kashmir. **A12**

THE ECONOMY Worsening storms, coupled with inflation, have left Texas with some of the highest home insurance rates in the nation. **A14**
Elon Musk said he will soon refocus on Tesla, which reported a 71 percent plunge in quarterly profits year over year. **A16**

THE REGION New charges emerged in the case of a nurse at a hospital near Richmond who is accused of harming infants. **B1**
Fairfax County Supervisor Pat Herrity left the GOP race for Virginia lieutenant governor, clearing the way for radio host John Reid. **B1**

STYLE Singer Lizzy McAlpine found fame on social media. Burnout led her to a role in Broadway’s “Floyd Collins.” **C1**

FOOD Eat it or toss it? Test your food safety knowledge with a quiz based on interviews with scientists. **E1**

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